

CXU Playground

RISC-V Custom Extension Development Framework

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2026

Motivation

CFU — exists

- ▶ Reusable across RISC-V cores
- ▶ Up to 255 functions
- ▶ CFU Playground: ready sandbox

One extension per thread,
assembly-only

CXU — spec only

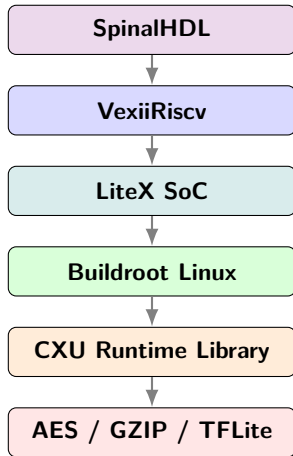
- ▶ Multiple simultaneous extensions
- ▶ Shared state
- ▶ C-level ABI, no inline assembly

No hardware implementation existed

This work

- ▶ First CXU hardware
- ▶ Full-stack open-source sandbox
- ▶ Benchmarked under Linux

Architecture



SpinalHDL

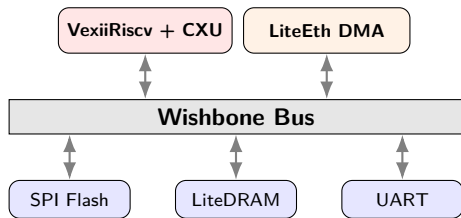
What it is

- ▶ Hardware description language built on Scala
- ▶ Generates Verilog/VHDL
- ▶ Modular plugin system: no plugin may alter the behaviour of another one

CXU plugin enable

```
VexiiRiscvLitex(  
    plugins += CxuPlugin(...args)  
)
```

LiteX SoC Framework



Target hardware

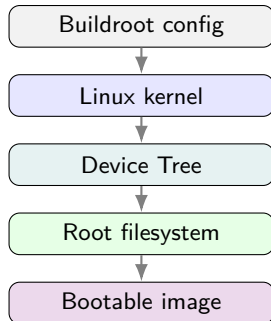
Target: Arty S7-50

- ▶ Spartan-7 XC7S50
- ▶ 50 MHz, 256 MB DDR3

FPGA utilisation (With AES example)

- ▶ CPU + SoC: 23%
- ▶ Single CXU extension: $\approx 1\%$
- ▶ Rest: free

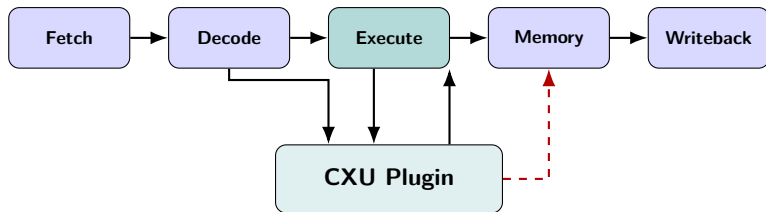
Buildroot



Boot sequence

LiteX BIOS → OpenSBI → U-Boot → Linux → CXU app

CXU Plugin



`cxidx` CSR selects active extension. Stalls pipeline for multi-cycle ops.

CXU Runtime Library

Without the library

```
// Manual extension select
csrcw cxidx, 2

// Custom opcode call (most compilers don't
support all RISC-V extensions)
.insn r CUSTOM_0, 0, 0,
      a0, a1, a2

// Core-specific, not portable
```

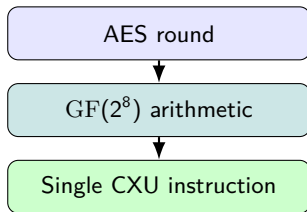
With the runtime library

```
// Pure C -- no assembly
cxu_select(CXU_AES);

uint32_t r = cxu_call(a, b);

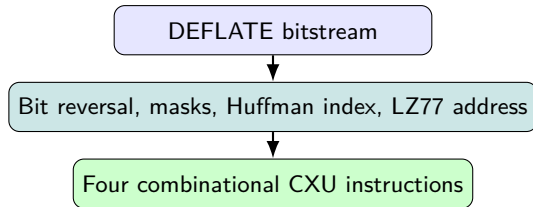
// Portable across CXU cores
```

Case Study: AES GF(2^8)



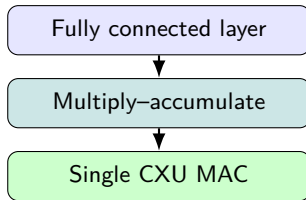
5.25 $\times$ speedup

Case Study: GZIP / DEFLATE



10% end-to-end speedup

Case Study: TFLite Micro MAC



13% compute speedup

Benchmarks

- ▶ **Bare-metal:** `mcycle` / `minstret` counters
- ▶ **Linux:** timing with utils provided in `"time.h"`
- ▶ Multiple input sizes to separate fixed overhead from per-byte savings
- ▶ Compiler flags identical (force only `-O3`) for both baseline and CXU versions

FPGA Resource Usage (Arty S7-50, XC7S50)

Extension	Logic cells	CXU cost	DSP48E1	Block RAM
AES	20,948	209 (1%)	4	36 tiles
GZIP	20,666	20	4	36 tiles
TFLite	20,698	folded	4	36 tiles

A single CXU extension will likely (unless it's very complex) consume little fpga fabric (~1% or less)

Similar extension interfaces / playgrounds

Feature	CFU Playground	FRANCIS-V	CXU Playground (this work)
Interface	CFU (single extension)	Core-V-XIF	CXU (multiple extensions)
Invocation	Assembly (<code>custom-0/1/2/3</code>)	C with compiler support	Pure C, portable API
Shared state	No	Yes (custom CSRs)	Yes (cxdata CSR)
OS support	Bare-metal only	Bare-metal + RTOS	Full Linux (Buildroot)
Portability	Across cores	CPU-specific	Designed for cross-core reuse

How to Add a New Extension

TODO:

Limitations

- ▶ **CSR access latency:** `cxidx/cxdata` are Wishbone-mapped, not pipeline registers.
- ▶ **No context-switch support:** CXU state not saved on Linux task preemption — single-process only.
- ▶ **No Device Tree entries:** extension addresses hard-coded.
- ▶ **Clock frequency:** combinational paths reduce $F_{\max}$.

Future Work

- ▶ Process context-switch support (save/restore CXU state)
- ▶ Native pipeline CSRs (bypass Wishbone)
- ▶ Device Tree integration (dynamic discovery)
- ▶ Multi-process tests and benchmarks under Linux

Summary

- ▶ CXU hardware implementation (SpinalHDL plugin for VexiiRiscv)
- ▶ CXU Playground: open-source, full-stack (LiteX + Buildroot + runtime lib)
- ▶ Three extensions that offer significant speedup: AES ($5.25\times$), GZIP (10%), TFLite MAC (13%)

<https://github.com/pmozil/CXU-playground>

<https://github.com/pmozil/vexiiriscv>

<https://github.com/pmozil/cxu-buildroot>